You see, each Foundation story assumes, as a background, all the previous stories, but I couldn't assume that every reader had read and remembered all the rest. Therefore each story had to manage to explain everything that had happened before, and as the series grew longer and more complex, this became more difficult. "—And Now You Don't" began with a teen-age girl reciting the previous events as part of a school assignment. I managed to work it in, but I decided it would have to be the last time.

My positronic robot series was completely different. Each story was independent, and knowledge of any of the previous stories was generally not required. It could go on forever.

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On October 21, 1948, I committed another one of my grosser stupidities. Sprague de Camp had come to New York to attend a meeting of the Authors Club. He was a great joiner and he suggested I attend as his guest. The meeting was for 7:00 p.m.

I am an early dinner eater, never eating later than six and sometimes eating as early as five. Since I tend to assume (as everyone does) that my personal idiosyncrasies are cosmic laws followed by all people, I presumed that the gathering was an after-dinner meeting.

Unfortunately, work kept me rather later than I expected that day and I fretted, rather petulantly, at not having enough time to eat in proper leisurely fashion before going to the meeting. I bolted dinner and arrived at the meeting in time —to find everything spread out for dinner.

Since I couldn't quite bring myself to admit to Sprague that I had already eaten dinner, I ate another dinner but, for the first time in my life, I ate slowly and abstemiously.

Catherine de Camp was there. I hadn't seen her in over a year and she was now forty-one, but she still looked as young and as beautiful as ever. This was a recurrent pattern. I wouldn't see her for some time and then would encounter her with the advance apprehension that I would view the ruins of a once-lovely woman—and she would always look as though time had stopped still.

15

I finally got the printed copies of my dissertation (prepared at huge expense by a professional printer) on October 27, 1948. I handed out copies to those